

The Seven Factors of Awakening

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 38:46

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Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So first of all we revised or were introduced to the actual technique that we're practising. And then we revised or were introduced to the hindrances, which is the Buddha's way of categorising all those things that take us away from meditation. There are other categories, as you know, the ten defilements and the ten *anusaya*. These five hindrances are just a way of looking at things that arise in our meditation that take us away. The idea is that we can see what it is, we note it, we're clear about it, and we know what to do to stop them taking over. We don't want to stop them arising, because that's the purification process, but we definitely don't want to get taken over by them. We want to remain awake within them and to use them actually to investigate these three characteristics, especially the characteristic of suffering, *dukkha*.

Remember there are three types of *dukkha* that the Buddha points to. The first one is *dukkha dukkhata*, the suffering of suffering. It's the relationship we have with suffering which is the suffering, not the original stuff that comes up. I'm sure you're all very clear on that by now: that the pain in the knee is not suffering, but our aversion towards it is the actual suffering. And we can prove that to ourselves by finding an equanimity with this painful knee. The same applies to our emotional life too. We can find a position with our depressions and anxieties and overexcitements and all that, in a way that it's carrying on and we're just with it. There's a separation. I think for most of us, that tends to be ninety-nine percent of the practice. It's ninety-nine percent perspiration and one percent inspiration.

However, running concurrent with that are the seven factors of enlightenment, and conjoining that or running along that too are the five spiritual faculties. The five and the seven meld into each other. The spiritual faculties are confidence, effort, awareness, concentration, and wisdom. And the seven factors of enlightenment are awareness, effort, concentration, calmness, interest, equanimity, and investigation of the Dhamma.

First of all, talking about this faith business, remember that in Buddhism faith or confidence is not to be confused with belief. Belief is putting our confidence in a statement to the point where we believe it to be true. What that obviously does is stop investigation. The whole of the Buddha's path is about self-realisation, in other words, me realising the truth. So if I just repeat the Four Noble Truths—that is suffering and the origin of suffering, which is desire—and then bow to the Buddha statue and think that's

it, well, it's an absolute waste of time.

Just believing in that sense is like so many things we believe that we don't actually know. We believe, for instance, that the Earth goes round the Sun. It doesn't happen perceptively, does it? Not for me, anyway. The Sun still comes overhead. But I have this absolute belief that we're going round the Sun. There's a whole load of science that I believe, but I don't know if it's true for me or not. I haven't tested any of this stuff. So a lot of stuff we just believe because in a sense it's neither here nor there. Whether the Sun goes round us or we go round the Sun, as long as it's shining, that's the important thing. But when it comes to the Dhamma, when it comes to the Buddha's teaching, it is about us realising what he realised. That means we have to go through the very same process he went through. In that sense he's not just an exemplar, he's the archetype. There's a Buddha within us following that same similar path.

So this faith is more of a confidence, and the confidence is in the teaching. The wisdom is in three stages. All of us came to this practice by hearing about it first of all, so it's received knowledge. Then if that interests us, if we're drawn to it, we tend to read a bit more and eventually we think about it. This thinking about it then becomes our own intellectual knowledge. Even if you quote everybody, it doesn't matter—it's your quote from now on. What was received now becomes your knowledge. I don't know about you, but at one point I was trying to understand relativity theory, and I would read it and say to myself, "Oh yeah," and then I tried to explain it. It was impossible. I couldn't explain it. So it's that gap between thinking you've understood it and actually when you try to explain what it is you've understood, you get all tongue-tied. Could you explain the Four Noble Truths to somebody else? If you can explain them, then that means you must have thought about it and you're able to pass on that information. If you can't do it, it's still at the level of received knowledge. That's the same with all the important teachings around dependent origination, around vipassanā. Could you introduce somebody to it?

And then of course that isn't enough—it has to be realised. That's where the vipassanā comes in. That's the next stage of *paññā*, of this wisdom, when you actually perceive it for yourself, actually realise it for yourself. So this confidence and this whole process of investigation and realisation are linked. Obviously if you didn't have confidence you wouldn't go into it, full stop—you'd go into some other form of spiritual practice. So that confidence underlies really everything that we do: putting faith in the teaching, faith in the tradition, faith in the Buddha. These are called spiritual faculties. They're what enable us to enter the path.

Then there's concentration and effort. And then there's awareness. If we now switch over to the seven factors, what we have is again this effort with concentration. Remember that concentration is a word that tends to make us tight, mainly because of our school days or whatever. If you think of it much more as a steadiness of attention—how long can you hold your attention on something?—that's what it's referring to. A real steady gaze. How long can you hold your attention? These days, because of the enormous amount of information we have to process, with computers and iPods and all the rest of it, our concentration tends to be a little bit short, especially, they say, of children. A couple of seconds and that's it, they're off

somewhere else. So a lot of our practice is to bring us into a state of steadiness of attention. And the effort that we need is just to keep that. That's the only effort you need: to keep that attention steady.

Now if the effort is too much, then what you get is restlessness. We're presuming now that in the meditation these hindrances aren't there for the moment. We're presuming that in fact there's clarity in the mind, there's a stillness, and there's concentration, this steadiness of attention, a focus. If some other stuff comes in apart from just maintaining that steadiness of attention—such as the idea of trying to see, trying to attain, trying to make the focus more focused—then you get this little bit of extra energy which starts shaking it. Before you know it, you find yourself getting quite restless. At worst, if the energy is really over the top, there tends to be a collapse in the meditation. Some of you might have experienced that, where it just stops and that's it really. It's difficult to describe if you haven't experienced it, but you basically have to take an afternoon off and start again. It just drops like that and you just can't do it. It's like when you force yourself to run and run and run and eventually the body just stops. That's a telltale to the meditator: you're putting too much effort into it.

On the other hand, if you don't put enough effort, then this steadiness of attention drops you into a state of unconsciousness. You'll know it's not sleep because when you fall asleep your body rocks and shakes and you start banging your head on the floor. But with this you're still sitting bolt upright, and anybody walking in the room would say, "Now there's a meditator," but actually you're just not there. You've gone asleep, completely asleep, and depending on the force of that concentration you can be there for quite some time. In the Hindu tradition there's a tale of a guru who asks for some water and then enters into this state. Many years afterwards, ten years afterwards, he wakes up and his first words are, "Where's my water?" Nothing's happened for ten years. It's just one of these little tales you get about states of unconsciousness. Unfortunately, in the Theravāda tradition, sometimes they make that state of unconsciousness into a jhānic state. To me that's a little bit of a confusion, but let that be.

There's a place in Chiang Mai, Wat Long Pern, where they teach this Mahāsī system. The teacher is a very old man, he doesn't teach himself, but the system's there. You really go at it—this is soft stuff compared to what they'll put you through—and then right towards the end of your three weeks, you're not allowed to sleep. During those three days, if you have a blackout they suggest to you that was Nibbāna. Well, I've always thought that was a bit fishy. In fact somebody turned up at the meditation centre in Sri Lanka and said this, and the chief monk there said to him, "Do you think it was Nibbāna?" He said, "No, I fell asleep." So it's a dodgy one, you have to be careful. If that happens to you, if you wake up and find yourself still sitting bolt upright, then you know: concentration's good, the focus is good, I'm just not putting enough effort in. Not enough effort to keep the wakefulness.

This tells us something about good sleep too. If a person finds difficulty in sleep, often it's the case that the underlying mental state beneath that unconsciousness is in a state of restlessness and it keeps bursting through, making us wake up. That's why the Buddha says if you practise loving-kindness before you sleep, it creates this lovely underlying state under sleep. You sleep well. You can do it on the breath if you find

the breath easier, but people often tend to rush around all day, come back, eat, watch TV, and then just launch themselves into bed when it's time. Of course that hasn't been a preparation. You have to prepare yourself before sleep. Very few people can just blank it out, and often that's not such a good sleep. You have to wind down at the end of the day—wind down, play some sleepy music or something like that. What you're creating is this subliminal level of beautiful mind.

So that's why they put effort and concentration together. Remember, I'm using the word concentration because that's the word you'll come across, but what we mean is steadiness of attention. These two are always linked, always balanced together. There's the case of a monk, whose name escapes me, who is trying very, very hard, getting nowhere, and he decides that he's had enough and he's going to go back to the lay life, get married and have a decent time for a change. When the Buddha hears about this, he goes and has a chat with him, and he says it's like tuning a string. It's not too tight and not too slack. You've got to be able to tune the string on an instrument—it would have been a stringed instrument, the *vīṇā*. That's how he describes it: getting that point where the effort is just right.

This is all part of our skills of meditation. This is us experimenting within ourselves to get the right level of concentration. Nobody can tell you that. All the Buddha could do was give this fellow an example: sometimes it's too much, sometimes it's too little, you've just got to get it right. Nobody can tell you how much effort to put in. We ourselves have to discover our own level of effort, our own level of concentration. That's part of the practice, part of becoming skilful.

When I started teaching, going back to the late nineties really, and even before that I was doing a little bit, I used to teach in the method of my old teacher, U Janaka. So even on a weekend retreat I had them up at half past three. Get in there, beat them up, sit there, don't move. There used to be this energy, like they're having these fusion reactors—this plasma—the room would be filled with this plasma, sitting there going through this dreadful pain. I used to do these really heavy retreats even for a weekend, because that's what I used to do, that's what I was brought up to do. And nobody came back. Only the real hard nuts came back, the sort of bruisers. So I thought, well, something's wrong. I even did it on my first long retreat here at Gaia House. I've a lot to thank Gaia House for, because my four years spent here was really my teacher training college. It was here, just seeing what the teachers were doing, recognising that maybe this was a bit of the wrong tack.

Frankly, of all the people whom I remember from when the Mahāśī teachers came in the late seventies—you hardly remember people, but a retreat would have a hundred, a hundred and fifty people. In those days the men and women were all separated, the Eastern way. The side of the men was chock-a-block, knee against knee, and the women were just up here, a few, and we'd be looking over thinking, "Why can't we?" I don't remember them. I don't think any of them actually ever came back. Very few that I remember. I got to Burma once and there were five or six, and I often wonder what happens to them, whether they're even still practising. I know one person gave up, and he came to see me. I'd just ordained in Birmingham, and it was this push, push, push, trying to get the passing, that insight. He came

to see me in Birmingham. I hadn't seen him for about four or five years. That year he'd spent ten thousand pounds on crack, as he told me. This was an ardent meditator.

Too much effort, and then that sense of failure. Within that, you give up really. Mind you, in those days there tended to be the erroneous idea that you went at it for six months and then it was sex, drugs, and rock and roll for the next six. Then you went to Burma to do a bit more headbanging. Because it never did get people very far, really. So I began to reflect on this, on the way Westerners, the Western culture, put tremendous effort into things compared to certain Eastern cultures. I began to stress the other two factors: interest and calmness. And people returned. This was a great breakthrough for me.

So this business of interest and calmness. Interest here is that fundamental curiosity that arises with intelligence. You see it with birds, you see it with all creatures that have some form of consciousness that we can conceive for ourselves.

I'll just give you this little thing to show you how intelligent. We think that we're the only species that plays with other species. You know, we play with dogs and cats. But I was at Kanduboda once, waiting in a line for a meal, and the place was always full of dogs and crows. They used to just put the food out on the floor, on the ground. It's all gone now, it's a bit cleaner. And there was a little dog, a little pup, chewing away at this rice. And a crow jumped towards it and bit its tail. The dog turned around, and the crow bounced back. The dog went back to eating, and the crow jumped forward, bit its tail. The dog turned around. I thought, well, that's very clever. The crow wants the rice. So he went the third time, and the dog turned around and then just walked away, fed up with it. And the crow, I swear, looked longingly after the little pup and then flew away. But when you see things like that, you think, well, a crow could become fully liberated.

So this business of curiosity is just a fundamental quality of this intelligence, this curiosity. And the word interest, I think, gets across the idea that it's joyful. In the list of seven factors of enlightenment, you'll see the Pāli word *pīti*. This *pīti* is also associated with these absorptions we're talking about, which means a mental state, a pure mental state of happiness. But here, it's the joy that arises when you're interested in something. Think about it, the times when you've really been interested in doing something. It's been full of joy. Now, even that interest can become too interested. It can take on this business of wanting to know too much. And that's why it's balanced with calmness.

So calmness and interest. And again, it's the usual thing. If you get too calm, you fall asleep. And if there's not enough calm, the interest gets too excited and you find yourself getting restless. So it's always this lovely balance.

The final one is equanimity with *dhammavicaya*. In the standing meditation that I did at the beginning, I was trying to point out the quality of equanimity. The quality of equanimity is to come from a place of don't know, to come from a place of not sure, as if this is the first time we've ever done it. The beginner's mind, as Zen would say. And it's also not an emotional involvement. It's not coming from a prejudicial

place. So these two factors describe this even-mindedness. That's another way of putting equanimity. Unfortunately, both the word equanimity and even-mindedness put the accent too much upon thought, but it's also an emotional state. It's also a calm, even emotional state.

In a sense, it's the qualities you would expect of a judge. You don't want the judge to get caught up in the clever arguments of lawyers, and you don't want them to get caught up in the baying of the crowd, the hang-ups. You want them to keep equanimous, above it all. And this allows us to investigate the Dhamma. Investigating the Dhamma simply means the three characteristics, the five defilements, the five hindrances that we've been talking about, the four noble truths. It can be anything which will then lead to understanding, to liberation.

Now if there's not that equanimity there, what we're tending to do is to look for something that we've conceived. And the mind is very clever, remember. So even though we've heard about these words Nibbāna and all that sort of stuff, unwittingly we can be searching for or looking for this sort of experience. We can have some idea of what it means to be a stream-enterer. Woo! And what that does is it distorts the looking. And with expectation of that sort, even if it's quite unconscious, there arises a certain disappointment, disappointment that it's not happening. There arises a feeling that you can't get it because you've got this ideal in your head about what a spiritual insight is or where you should be. So again, that leads to discouragement, giving up the path. And if unfortunately you do see what you've conceived, then surely you're deluded. You've simply manifested what you wanted.

I had one lovely experience with a man at the centre. He came back and said that he'd had this amazing experience, believe it or not, while he sat on the toilet. Now if you remember, Luther also had his great insight while evacuating, so those are moments of relief and release, remember. So one can expect to have amazing insight on the pot.

Anyway, he came back. The way he described it, it was obviously a lovely mental state, but it was obviously from his description not what he thought it was. But there was no way he was going to believe it wasn't Nibbāna. That was it. He was convinced that he'd had this experience and that's it. So now, what happens to such a person? Well, they might stop investigating. They might think, well, that's it, and that's it. Why should I carry on practising or anything else? So there's always that problem that when we have an experience, we overestimate. The overestimation is often coming from some preconceived idea as to what a spiritual insight is.

Generally speaking, if we have an insight, you might go to a teacher and say what it is, and he might explain it and put it into context. But the spiritual progress is that as you go along, your next insight throws light on the one you've had before. So eventually there comes a balance about what you feel you've experienced and what you haven't. It's best not to decide. You can definitely, if you have an experience, say what it was. That's not a problem. But it's rating it which can be the problem. It's best just simply not to rate it, but to say to yourself, this is what I experienced, and this is what I have come to understand.

And what I've come to understand ought to affect us systemically. It's no good going around saying, you know, I had this amazing experience of interconnectedness, and then going around shooting everybody. That interconnectedness, when it falls systemically into the heart, expresses itself as love. And that's what love is, isn't it? It's the heart's connectedness with all beings. And if it doesn't do that, then it's just been a head thing. It hasn't been a real spiritual experience. That's the difference.

Now you'll notice that all these factors everybody has. The only thing that turns them into factors of enlightenment is dhammavicaya, investigating the Dhamma. Everybody's got concentration and calmness and interest and effort and confidence in one way or another. But it's actually getting all those qualities and placing them into this sort of investigation that brings about spiritual insights.

When we begin meditating, when we sit like this, you're trying to manifest these factors both mentally and physically. Physically you're calming, you're stilling the body. Mentally you're calming the heart, you're silencing the mind. And you're finding a position within yourself as the objective observer. Ñāṇaponika, in his very good book *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation*, calls it the observation post. It's like a crow's nest on a ship. You've found a particular place. These factors of enlightenment, as you move to that place, withdraw into that place, all these factors of enlightenment are in the looking. That's why awareness is the governing factor.

Everything I've said this evening is virtually a complete waste of time, because if you centred the whole of your effort just on this awareness, all the faculties come up to support it. It's a natural movement of these faculties to support that awareness. That's why we always start off with the breath and establishing awareness, this mindfulness, on the breath.

Now remember, what we're talking about is this satipaṇṇā, this awareness-intuitive faculty within us. Some traditions call it Buddha nature. And what it's trying to do is to abstract itself, to bring itself out of this morass of the psychophysical organism. And as it does so and finds this place where it can observe the body, heart and mind, it is pure awareness at that point. And it's when the light goes on of the intelligence that all these factors are already there in the looking. That's why we can have all these factors there when there is enormous restlessness, enormous dullness, the mind expressing itself, the heart emoting, and yet you can maintain this poise. But we get it through the practice of first of all quietening the body and slowly raising ourselves up to the level of the objective observer. Perfectly clear.

So our practice is to always get into that position of the observation post. And once we're there, all the factors must be there. And that's basically our practice. That's what we're constantly trying to do. And once it's there, this intelligence, this curiosity is able to investigate. And in investigating what it sees, what it's experiencing out there in the mind, in the heart, out there—that's why the noting word is so powerful, because it pushes things away from us, makes us look at them as objects—it slowly begins to realise its own nature. That's the process.

So these seven factors, you'll see some are passive and some are active. It's that quality of the feminine

and the masculine. Eventually we ourselves begin to develop those two qualities within ourselves, their balance, the passive and the active, the feminine and the masculine. And what balances it is awareness. So you have, on the more passive side, the concentration and the calmness and the equanimity. And on the active side, you have the effort, the interest, and the investigation. And they have to be absolutely balanced for insight to come.

One of our dangers, now that we know all this, is to be worrying about whether my interest is high enough. So that's why I say, abandon all that completely. Forget you've heard a word. And just put your whole effort into just this moment-to-moment awareness. It's enough. It's enough.

And that's what the Buddha says in the Discourse on How to Establish Mindfulness. He says, start off by observing the breath, contacting the body in the breath. And you know it's long or short, coarse or fine. And then as you keep watching it, you train yourself on that until the body's become a bit calmer, the heart's calmer, the mind is still. And then you begin to observe. By now you've found this observation post. And then you begin to observe the quality of impermanence, the beginning and end of each breath. And he says, just keep doing this until there is enough awareness and enough intelligence, this intuitive intelligence, for insight to arise.

Essentially, the practice is very simple. Very simple indeed. It doesn't take a great big intellect. Remember the story of the monk who was so dull that when he learned a phrase of the Buddha's teachings—because in those days nothing was written, it was all learned by rote—when he learned a phrase from the Buddha's teaching, it knocked the phrase he'd just learned out of his head. And his brother said he was just too dull to be a monk and he'd better go back to lay life. When the Buddha heard this, he went to see him and gave him a very simple exercise. He gave him a clean cloth and said, just rub it and wipe your face from the sweat, and just keep saying "impermanent, impermanent." And before long he was fully liberated. It didn't work for me, so there's a special—the Buddha has a special insight into where you are. This story is told to show that you don't need intellect.

As opposed to that, there's a story in the commentary about a monk who was extremely clever, a real scholar and an expert, and all his students become liberated. And then he starts thinking to himself, how is it I'm the teacher and all these students become liberated, but I'm not liberated? So he goes to see them. And one after one, they see this guy's just too intellectually conceited. So they kept saying, well, I'm not really the one to help you. Why don't you go and see so-and-so? And he went all the way down the line until they gave him to a child. That was very humiliating, but he thought, well, we'll have a go. And the child took him to this anthill. When ants move out of their anthills, snakes live in them. It becomes a snake's home. So the child said, supposing this anthill had six holes and you wanted to get the snake out, what would you do? The teacher said, well, you'd just stop up five holes and it would have to come out from the sixth. The child said, that's what you've got to do. Stop the five senses and everything comes out through the mind. And observe. He went away and in no length of time, fully liberated.

I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your wise reflection and excellent development of the seven factors of enlightenment, arrive at that wonderful place, Nibbāna, sooner rather than later.

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